



FAFSA + Financial Aid Appeal Toolkit

Get unstuck, document changed circumstances, and ask for the right review.

MADE FOR

Students and FAFSA contributors

Use this toolkit as a planning guide. Requirements, deadlines, and availability are set by each school, scholarship, agency, or provider. EFF cannot guarantee funding or outside assistance.

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FAFSA rescue checklist

- Use only StudentAid.gov
- Student and contributor each use their own FSA ID
- Match legal names and dates exactly
- Complete every contributor invitation
- Provide required consent and signature
- Review the FAFSA Submission Summary for errors
- Send corrections and track school receipt

NEED HELP?

Contact the Federal Student Aid Information Center or your school's financial aid office. Never share an FSA ID password.

When to request professional judgment

Ask the financial aid office whether it can review documented circumstances that the FAFSA does not fully reflect.

- Job loss or major income reduction
- Death, divorce, separation, or loss of family support
- High unreimbursed medical or caregiving expenses
- Housing instability or unusual dependency circumstances

Schools decide whether and how to adjust aid. An appeal does not guarantee additional funding.

What changed, when it changed, and how it affects college costs

Email template

SUBJECT

Request for Professional Judgment Review - [Student Name / ID]

Dear Financial Aid Office,

I am requesting guidance on a professional judgment review because [brief change] occurred on [date]. This change is not fully reflected in my current FAFSA information and affects my ability to cover [specific costs]. Please tell me which

form and documents your office requires, the review timeline, and whether my account can be protected while the request is pending.

Thank you,

[Name] | [Student ID] | [Phone]

- Use the school's secure upload system
- Keep copies of every submission
- Ask for written confirmation and a follow-up date